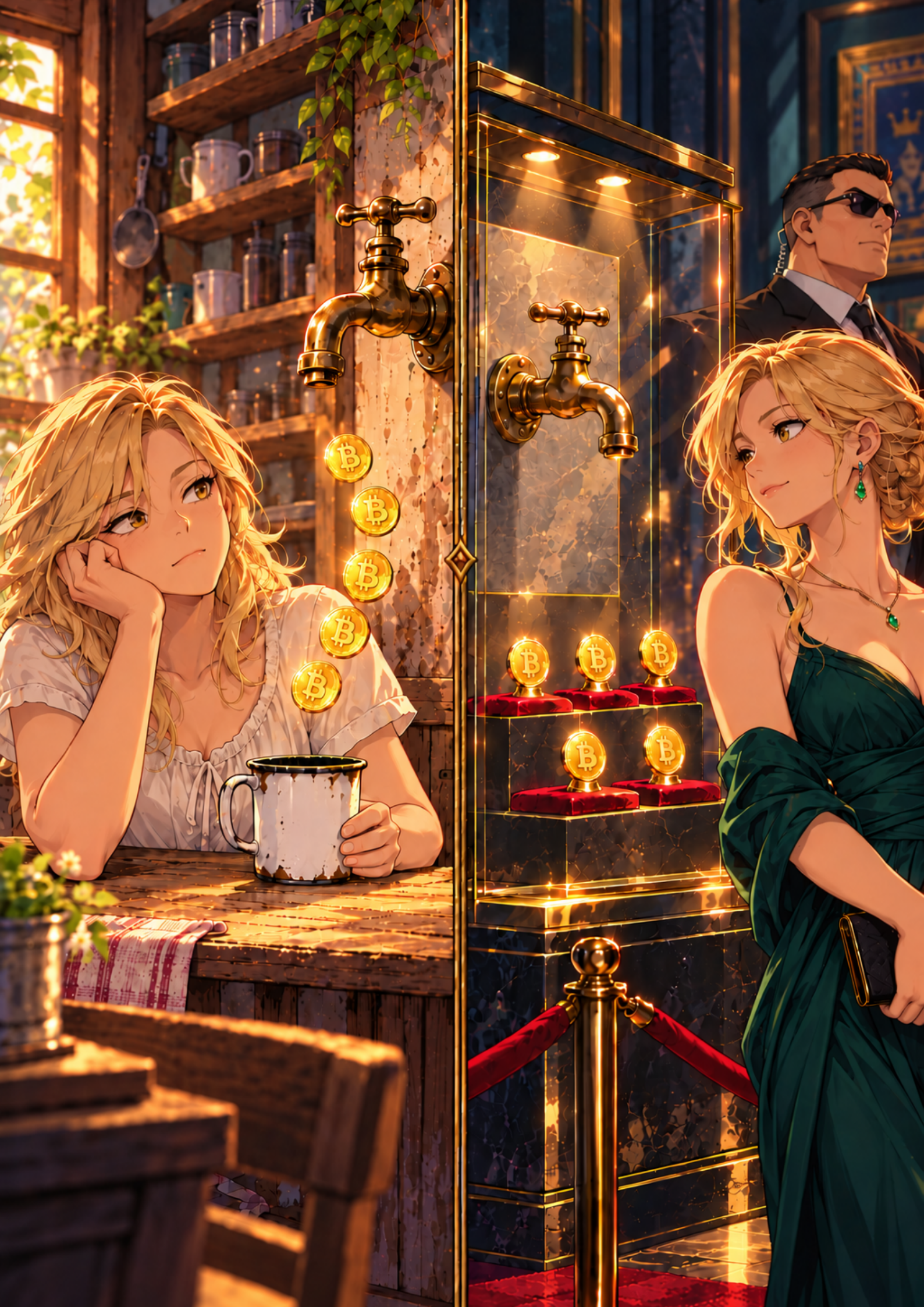


THE FAUCET

009 / 11 JUN 2010 / BITCOIN / COMMON

FREE THEN. A FORTUNE LATER.

A brass tap drops five golden coins towards an ordinary mug. The blonde woman beside it barely looks up from her kitchen table. Across the central divide, the same woman wears an emerald evening dress beside five coins displayed under glass. The two scenes turn one giveaway into a contrast between easy access and an imagined future fortune.

On 11 June 2010, Gavin Andresen announced his first Bitcoin coding project: a website that gave away bitcoins. He stocked it with 1,100 BTC to start and offered five per customer. Mining could mean waiting for a computer to generate coins, while buying them was still awkward. Gavin wanted newcomers to get a handful and try Bitcoin for themselves.

The forum answered almost at once. Laszlo Hanyecz, whose pizza exchange appears on the previous card, replied, “Awesome!” Other users asked how to keep the site funded. Later that day Gavin reported a balance of 1,135 BTC after donations and clarified that the original limit was five bitcoins per IP address, rather than five every day. A week later Satoshi praised the idea as a way for new users to have coins to play with.

The woman, kitchen, display case and guard are fictional. They do not identify a faucet recipient or document what anyone later became worth. The five coins on each side repeat the same symbolic amount, not two payouts, and the faucet distributed existing bitcoin rather than creating it. FREE THEN. A FORTUNE LATER. is an editorial caption, not a historical quotation, current valuation or promise of future returns.

HIDDEN IN THE ART

01 THE KITCHEN TAP

The ordinary brass tap turns the website's name into an everyday object. It is a visual metaphor, not a documented installation: the real faucet delivered bitcoin online.

02 FIVE COINS REPEATED

Five coins fall on the left; five stand on red cushions on the right. Both groups recall the five-BTC offer. Repeating them across the split does not mean a visitor received ten.

03 THE EMERALD DRESS

The casually dressed woman on the left reappears in an emerald evening dress and jewellery on the right. She is one fictional character across two imagined scenes, not a known recipient.

04 THE WATCHFUL GUARD

The suited guard behind the display gives the imagined future scene a sense of protected wealth. He is not a historical faucet employee or evidence that a particular claimant became rich.

SOURCE & ART NOTE

Gavin Andresen's 11 June 2010 announcement and discussion, including Satoshi's 18 June reply; his later faucet changes thread. The original offer was five per customer, initially limited by IP, not a daily grant. The woman, physical taps and coins, kitchen, dress, case and guard are fictional. The future fortune is symbolic, not an actual recipient's biography or a current BTC valuation. The card caption is editorial wording, not a historical quotation.